CHAPTER 16

Interactive Ruby

If you want to play with Ruby, we recommend Interactive Ruby—irb, for short. irb is a Ruby command-line "shell" similar in concept to an operating system shell (complete with job control). It is sometimes called a REPL, which is an abbreviation for "Read, Evaluate, Print Loop," and provides an environment where you can play around with the language in real time.

You launch irb at the command prompt:

```
$ irb
```

irb displays the value of each expression as you complete it. For instance:

```
$ irb
irb(main):001:0* a = 1 +
irb(main):002:0* 2 * 3 /
irb(main):003:0> 4 % 5
=> 2
irb(main):004:0> 2 + 2
=> 4
irb(main):005:0> x = _
=> 4
irb(main):006:0> x
=> 4
irb(main):007:1* def test
irb(main):008:1*   puts "Hello, world!"
irb(main):009:0> end
=> :test
irb(main):010:0> test
Hello, world!
=> nil
irb(main):011:0>
```

A couple of things about that session. If you typed along with it in Ruby 3.1 or higher, you may have noticed that irb tried to autocomplete text as you typed it. You may also have noticed that it color-coded the text as you entered it, and even backdented the `end` line to line up.

Also, irb always stores the result of the last expression in as special variable called `_`, as you can see in lines 5 and 6, that can be a useful way to capture data and use it in the future.